

ENTRY MANAGEMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

ENTRY MANAGEMENT LESSON

There may be nothing more frustrating in Bridge than looking across at dummy and seeing three good tricks sitting there - and you have no way to reach them.

Entry Management may sound classy, but it just means being in the right place at the right time.

Plan Early and Wisely:

The contract is 3NT and West leads the ♠7.

♠ A 8 3 2

♥ A J 6 4

♦ A Q 5 3

♣ A



♠ K 6

♥ 7 5 3

♦ 6 4 2

♣ K Q J 10 3

If you play low from dummy you will be forced to win your ♠K immediately, or at trick 2 after East wins trick 1 and returns another ♠.

Now you will go down because after unblocking dummy's ♣A you have no entry back to your hand.

You may have planned early, but you didn't play wisely. The contract is absolutely cold as long as you win the first trick with dummy's ♠A. Then you unblock the ♣A and you still have the ♠K entry to your hand.

Simple enough, right? Just use common sense and think **before** you play, not after.

And the good news is that most of the entry problems you encounter will be just that easy to solve.

But there are a few tougher cases, and a few strategies to get around them, which is why you decided to read this lesson.

Cheap Tricks, and when not to take them:

Bridge players realize early that it is obviously a good idea to win a trick with the smallest card that they can, thereby keeping their higher cards for later. It's hard to ignore that principle, even when you should.

Here's another 3NT contract. (Yes, Bridge writers love to use 3NT contracts.)

West leads the ♠3. East plays a low ♠.

♠ Q J 10
 ♥ 7 3
 ♦ K J 10 9 8
 ♣ 8 6 4

Suppose you let dummy's ♠10 win the trick.
 When you try to establish the ♦ suit East will take the second ♦ and return a ♠.

If you play low from your hand West will take the ♠A and play another ♠ to your ♠K.
 You will never reach dummy's good ♦s.

♠ K 7 5
 ♥ A Q 3 2
 ♦ Q 5
 ♣ A K 7 2

If instead you play your ♠K when East leads that second ♠ West will allow your ♠K to hold the trick.
 You will never reach dummy's good ♦s.

It is easy to now see where things went wrong.
 Get your ♠K out of the way by using it to win the first trick and dummy's ♠ Q J will guarantee an entry to the ♦ suit.

Unblocking intermediate cards:

Sometimes a hand looks so simple that you don't spot the danger until too late.

The contract is 6NT. West leads the ♠6.
 East takes the ♠A and returns the ♠J.

♠ 5 3 2
 ♥ 6 2
 ♦ 8 5 4
 ♣ A K Q 5 3

This looks like a cinch as long as the ♣s don't split 4-0.

You win the second trick with your ♠K, play the ♣4 to dummy's ♣Q, and breathe a sigh of relief when both defenders follow suit (it turns out they split 3-1).

♠ K 7 4
 ♥ A K Q
 ♦ A K Q
 ♣ 8 7 6 4

A few minutes later that sigh of relief turns into a cry of anguish when you discover that you can only win 4 ♣ tricks because after taking ♣ A K Q you will take the next ♣ in your hand!

Try it again from trick 2. This time play the ♣8 to dummy's ♣Q, and play the ♣7 and ♣6 under the ♣K and ♣A. Then, when you play dummy's ♣5 you can slip your ♣4 underneath it!

Overtaking to save an entry:

There is another way the sacrifice of a high card may pay off as an entry.

The contract is 3NT. West leads the ♠Q.

♠ 6
 ♥ 8 4 3
 ♦ A Q 10 9 8 7
 ♣ K 5



♠ A K 4 2
 ♥ A 7 6 2
 ♦ K
 ♣ A 8 6 4

Outside the ♦ suit you have 5 winners and no chance of creating any more.

So you need to get at least 4 ♦ tricks.

Suppose you win the first trick, play your ♦K, then go to dummy with the ♣K and start running the ♦s. All will be well if they split 3-3 but a 4-2 split is more likely with one defender holding ♦ J x x x.

Now try it this way. Win the first trick, play your ♦K, **OVERTAKE IT WITH THE ♦A**, then continue with ♦Q, ♦10. Somebody will win their ♦J but you still have that precious ♣K dummy entry to those other good ♦s.

The ♦K was worth more as an entry than it was as a high card.

Finessing for an entry:

That title doesn't sound like much of a daring strategy - of course there are times when you will have to finesse to get the entry you need.

Ahh, but here we are talking about a finesse that would otherwise be completely unnecessary, one which, if it loses, will actually throw a sure trick away.

The contract is 6♣. West leads the ♥Q.

♠ K Q 9 7 6 3
 ♥ 6 4 2
 ♦ A J
 ♣ 4 2



♠ --
 ♥ A K 5 3
 ♦ K 8
 ♣ A K Q J 9 8 7

You have 2 ♥ losers. A 3-3 split in the suit would allow you to set up your fourth ♥ but West's opening lead makes you think he probably has 4 or 5 ♥s.

You decide you must establish some ♠ tricks in dummy, but you need two entries for that play, one to get over there the first time and the second to get back after you have dislodged their ♠A. Unfortunately you have only one sure entry, the ♦A.

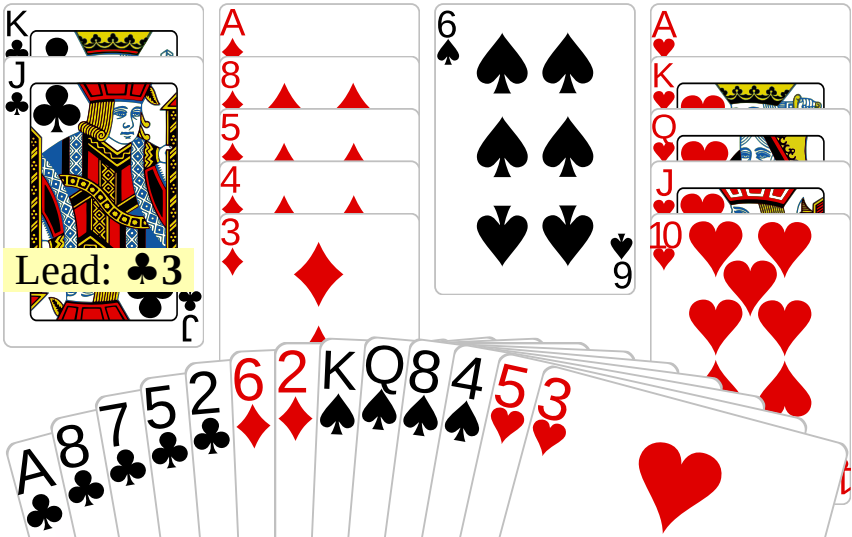
Win the first trick. Pull trumps in 2 or 3 rounds. Play a small ♦ and when West plays low finesse the ♦J - the unnecessary finesse. Today it wins. Now play the ♠K and when East plays a low card discard a ♥ loser. West can win the ♠A but you win his return, enter dummy with the ♦A and discard your other ♥ loser on the ♠Q.

Now ask yourself this: How good would West have to be to put his ♦Q on your first ♦ play to deprive you of that entry? Pretty good, I'd say.

There are other scenarios, many involving the sacrifice of a winner to gain an entry, and while we could go on and on and on . . .

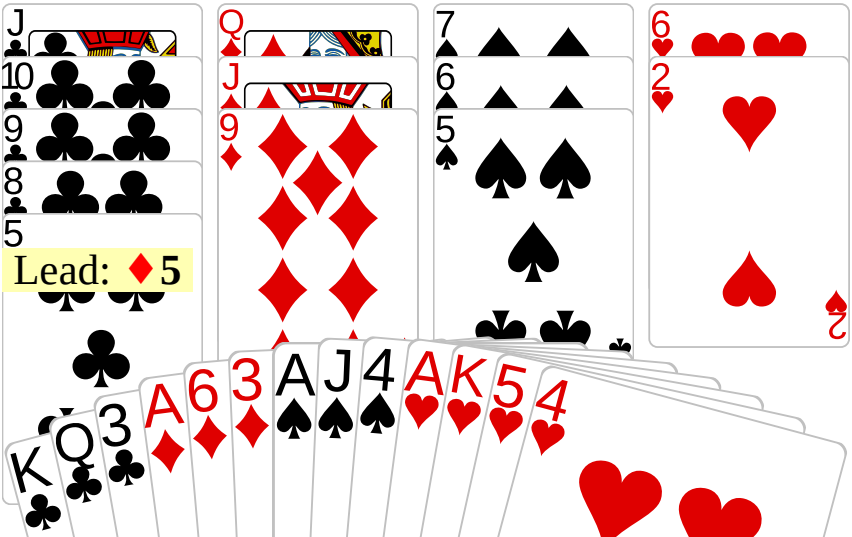
. . . 20 examples should be worth more than another 2000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



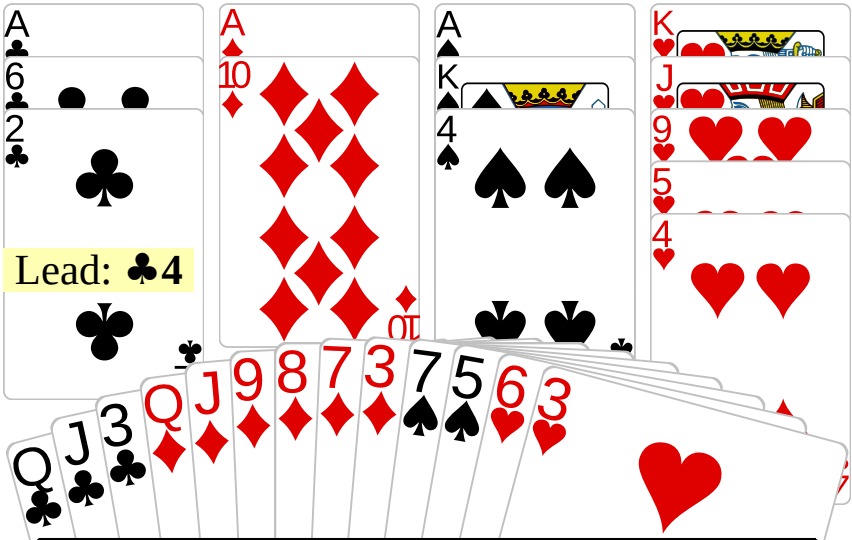
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



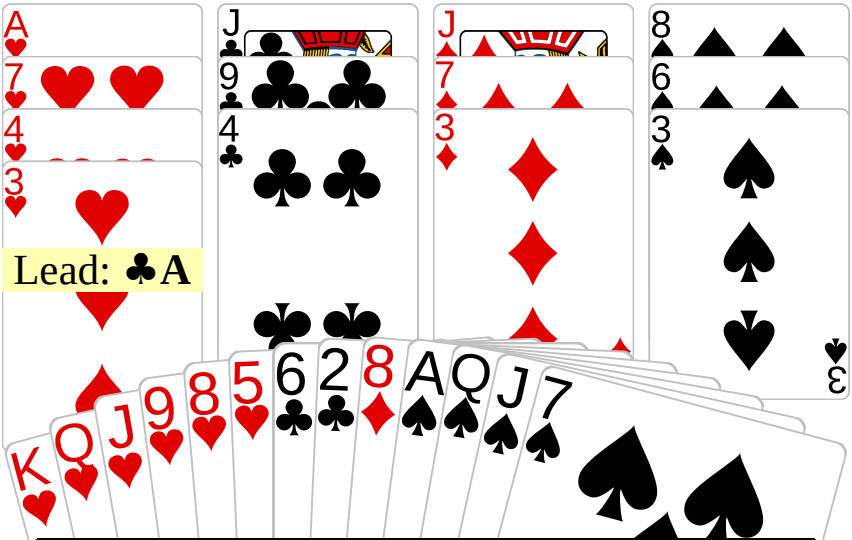
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



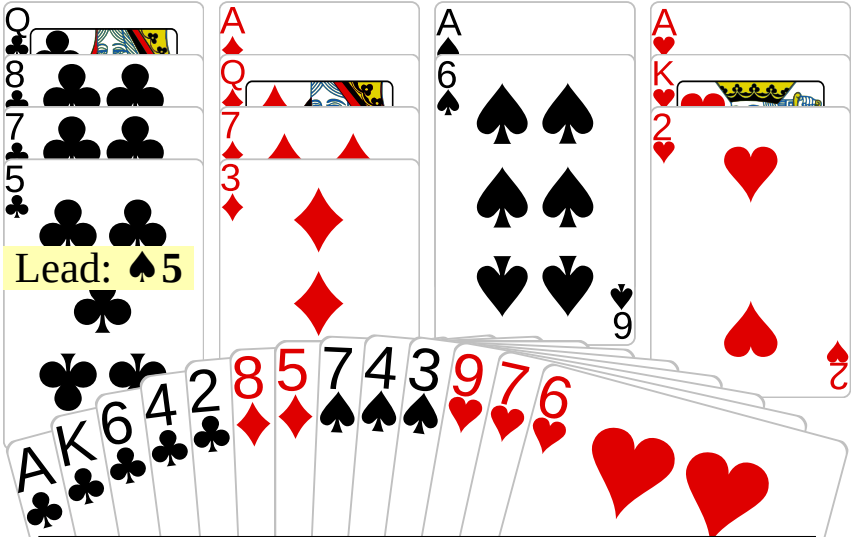
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: 4♥ Goal: at most ____ losers



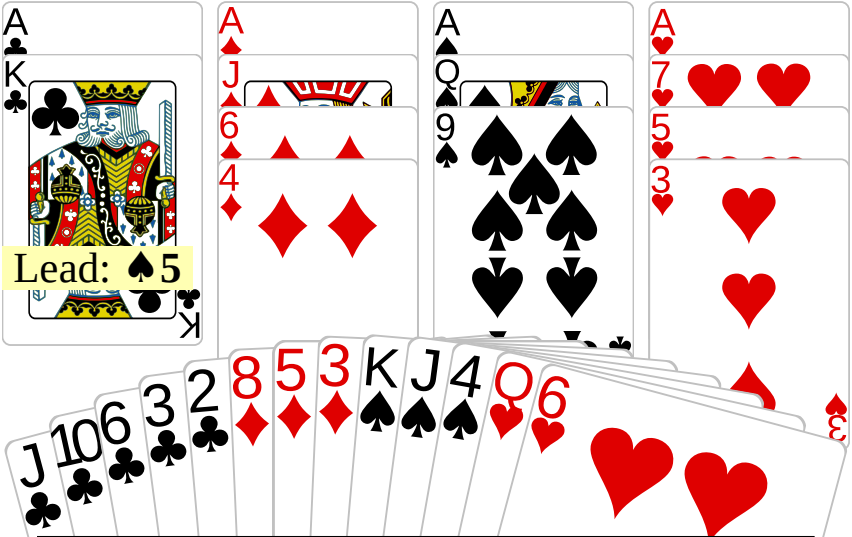
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 6 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣3

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦5

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣4

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣A

Board: 5
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠5

Board: 6
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠5

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 9 2
 ♥ 9 7 4 2
 ♦ K Q J 9
 ♣ Q 9

♠ K Q 8 4

♥ 5 3

♦ 6 2

♣ A 8 7 5 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A J 7 5 3

♥ 8 6

♦ 10 7

♣ 10 6 4 3

♠ 6

♥ A K Q J 10

♦ A 8 5 4 3

♣ K J

West	North	East	South
			1 ♥
Pass	1 ♠	Pass	3 ♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♣3			

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♣3.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=5 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 8

You only need one more winner and your ♠ K Q will provide it. So, is there anything that could go wrong? - - Like could you mess up your entry?

Suppose you play the ♣J from dummy on the first trick. And then suppose East puts the ♣Q on. If you take your ♣A you have used your entry to the ♠ K Q before you established one of them. But if you don't take the trick West will play another ♣ to remove dummy's ♣K with the same effect. So what should you do?

It's easy once you think about it. Just win the opening lead with dummy's ♣K. Then, while it's fresh in your mind play to your ♠ K Q to establish the one extra winner you need. Then it's just a question of taking your winners.

Hasty play to the first trick is one of the weaknesses of losing bridge players.

Making a plan before they play to the first trick is one of the strengths of winning bridge players.

Board 2

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 7 6 5

♥ 6 2

♦ Q J 9

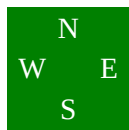
♣ J 10 9 8 5

♠ Q 10 8 3

♥ Q J 9 7

♦ 7 4

♣ A 6 2



♠ A J 4

♥ A K 5 4

♦ A 6 3

♣ K Q 3

♠ K 9 2

♥ 10 8 3

♦ K 10 8 5 2

♣ 7 4

West

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

Lead: ♦ 5

North

Pass

East

2NT

South

Pass

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♦ 5. You play the ♦ 9 from dummy and North plays the ♦ 4.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=0 Total = 5

The bad news is that you must come up with 4 more winners! The good news is dummy's ♣ suit.

You can drive out the ♣ A, then get over to dummy for those ♣ winners. You will be able to get over to dummy, won't you?

Not if you let the ♦ 9 hold the first trick. The defender with the ♣ A will hold it up until the third round, then South will be able to play his ♦ K so as to prevent you from entering dummy.

But take first trick with the ♦ A and the ♦ Q J will be there guaranteeing you an entry to those two good ♣s.

It goes against the grain to put your ♦ A on a trick that dummy has already won with the ♦ 9. It seems like you are wasting a trick.

But look carefully at the ♦ situation. You are going to get exactly two ♦ tricks no matter when you play your ♦ A. So you don't lose a trick, but you do gain an entry.

Board 3

North Deals

None Vul

♠ J 10 3
♥ Q 10 7 2
♦ 6 5
♣ K 10 7 4

♠ A K 4
♥ K J 9 5 4
♦ A 10
♣ A 6 2



♠ Q 9 8 6 2
♥ A 8
♦ K 4 2
♣ 9 8 5

♠ 7 5
♥ 6 3
♦ Q J 9 8 7 3
♣ Q J 3

West	North	East	South
	1♥	Pass	1NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♣4			

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♣4.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

Looks like you're going to need some ♦ tricks. Lots of them. And it also looks like you are going to have to be very careful with entries, which shouldn't surprise you at this time. So what is your first key move?

The ♣ situation is exactly the same as the ♦s in Deal 2, but flipped North to South. And you must handle it exactly the same way - jump up with the ♣A right away to preserve the ♣ Q J combination as a sure entry to your hand.

Having done that, are your problems (and thinking) over?

Everyone follows low.

East plays low.

Not quite, there is one more hurdle to hurdle. You must put all thought of a ♦ finesse far out of your mind. Play ♦ A, then ♦ 10, overtaking with ♦ J and continuing the suit until the King appears. Now you should be able to come to 9 tricks unless there is a very unfortunate distribution which lets the defenders score 3 ♥ tricks along with their 1 ♣ and 1 ♦.

Once again notice that playing the ♣A at trick one doesn't cost a thing, you get two ♣ tricks however you play it.

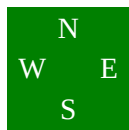
Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A Q J 7
 ♥ K Q J 9 8 5
 ♦ 8
 ♣ 6 2

♠ 10 2
 ♥ 10 2
 ♦ Q 9 6 4
 ♣ A K Q 8 3



♠ 8 6 3
 ♥ A 7 4 3
 ♦ J 7 3
 ♣ J 9 4

♠ K 9 5 4
 ♥ 6
 ♦ A K 10 5 2
 ♣ 10 7 5

West	North	East	South
1♥	Pass	2♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			
4♥ by West			
Lead: ♣A			

with your ♥5 did you? Surely you ruffed with the ♥8?

So, you ruffed the ♣ with the ♥8, pulled one round of trumps with the ♥K, pulled the last trump by playing ♥9 to ♥A and finessed the ♠. Then ♥5 to ♥7, finesse the ♠ a second time. Play ♠A and ruff the fourth ♠ in dummy.

If you ruffed with the ♥8 that is a good sign. But remember, this is the fourth Deal of a set where you are watching entries carefully.

Ask yourself if you would have done the correct thing at the table, say playing for the Bermuda Bowl championship.

West is to play 4♥. North leads the ♣A, ♣K, ♣Q.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 4

There is nothing to be done about the 2 ♣s you've already lost, and the ♦ loser is also inescapable. So you cannot afford a ♠ loser which means you will have to find the ♠K with South and finesse him out of it.

That won't be a problem, will it?

North continues with the ♣Q; dummy plays the ♣J and South the ♣10.

No, no problem. You will probably have to finesse twice so you will need two dummy entries, but the trump suit will provide both of those, the ♥A and ♥7, as long as you saved your ♥5 for the second entry. Wait a minute, you surely didn't ruff that ♣

Board 5

South Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q 10 8
 ♥ J 10 5 3
 ♦ K 9 2
 ♣ J 10 3

♠ 7 4 3

♥ 9 7 6

♦ 8 5

♣ A K 6 4 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K J 9 5 2

♥ Q 8 4

♦ J 10 6 4

♣ 9

♠ A 6

♥ A K 2

♦ A Q 7 3

♣ Q 8 7 5

West	North	East	South
			1 ♦
Pass	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♠ 5			

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠ 5.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=5 Total = 9

Wow! The winners add up to 9 already. We have assumed that ♣s will split no worse than 3-1, which is exactly how they do split. Is there any other pitfall you might need to worry about?

You win the ♠ A.

Just one minor problem. The ♣s will block if you are not careful! So you win the ♠ A, then play dummy's ♣Q. Next you play dummy's ♣8 to your ♣K. Then your ♣A on which you put dummy's ♣7. Aha! Now when you play your ♣6 you will be able to keep the lead.

If the ♣5 and ♣6 were swapped around the contract could not be made.

As they are, though, the contract is cold. But only if you are a good bridge player!

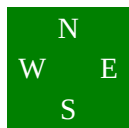
Board 6

West Deals

E-W Vul

♠ A Q 9
 ♥ A 7 5 3
 ♦ A J 6 4
 ♣ A K

♠ 6 3
 ♥ J 10 9 8 2
 ♦ Q 10 2
 ♣ 9 7 4



♠ K J 4
 ♥ Q 6
 ♦ 8 5 3
 ♣ J 10 6 3 2

♠ 10 8 7 5 2
 ♥ K 4
 ♦ K 9 7
 ♣ Q 8 5

West	North	East	South
2 ♣	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			
3NT by East			
Lead: ♠ 5			

to your ♠ J. Play your ♣ J (and another one if necessary) to establish the ♣ suit. Win whatever red card they play next with dummy's Ace. Play the ♠ Q to your ♠ K and cash your established ! C(s). Dummy's other red Ace will be your ninth trick.

The more you make a point of looking for entries the easier they are to find.

You'd have to be very careless to miss this one.

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♠ 5.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 7

Needing two winners you will naturally consider your 5-card ♣ suit. After unblocking the ♣ A K you will need two entries to your hand; one to lead the ♣ J and drive out the ♣ Q, then a second to enjoy your good ♣ s.

The ♠ suit will provide one entry easily, but should you depend on the ♥ Q for the second entry?

No, for two reasons. Firstly the ♥ Q only gives you a 50% chance of being an entry. But more importantly, you already have your two sure entries in ♠ s. As long as you take the first trick with dummy's ♠ A both your ♠ K and ♠ J can be entries.

Win the ♠ A. Play off dummy's ♣ A K. Lead the ♠ 9